CATHRINE VALENTIN KJÆR

Postdoctoral Researcher, University of Zurich (IPZ) · Ph.D. Candidate, European University Institute

cathrine.kjaer@ipz.uzh.ch · LinkedIn · Google Scholar · Website

Profile

My research examines how political influence operates in digital environments. This research agenda builds on the idea that the digitalization of politics fundamentally changes the nature of political influence. As politics has moved onto large-scale social media platforms, it now unfolds under structural conditions that differ fundamentally from traditional arenas. These environments change the conditions for political influence. I study how these structural features reshape mechanisms of political influence and how individual-level effects aggregate into group-level dynamics.

I address these questions using a combination of quantitative methods across multiple data sources. In some projects, I conduct large-scale social media data collection and computational text analysis; in others, I analyze citizens' online engagement with misinformation. I am currently conducting an online survey experiment on the political influence of online in-groups, recruiting respondents via targeted social media advertising and simulating the group-level consequences of these dynamics using an agent-based model.

I have advanced training in quantitative methods, including survey and survey-experimental design, and I am fluent in R and Stata. I have experience with agent-based modelling, collecting social media data via platform APIs, and collaborating with computer scientists.

Education

Ph.D. in Political Science, *European University Institute* 2022 – Expected 2026
Dissertation: Political persuasion in a Digital Reality.
Supervisors: Simon Hix and Arnout van de Rijt.

MSc in Political Science, *University of Copenhagen* 2019 – 2021
Specialization: Advanced quantitative methods for political behavior.

BSc in Political Science, *University of Southern Denmark* 2015 – 2018

Positions

Postdoctoral Researcher, *Chair of Digital Democracy (Prof. Karsten Donnay)* Sept. 2026–Present
Institut für Politikwissenschaft (IPZ), University of Zurich

Copenhagen Center for Social Data Science (SODAS), *University of Copenhagen* 2020–2022

- *Research Assistant (full-time) — HOPE Project* 2021–2022
  Co-author of two peer-reviewed publications.
- *Student Assistant (part-time) — HOPE Project* 2020–2021
  Assisted with content classification and grant applications.

HOPE Project: Carlsberg Foundation–funded interdisciplinary research collaboration examining COVID-19, public opinion, and online misinformation.

Publications

Kjær, C. V., Johansen, N., Marjanovic, S. V., Baglini, R. B., & Adler-Nissen, R. (2022). Misinformation, social status og latterliggørelse: En undersøgelse af danskeres spredning af og reaktioner på Covid-19 misinformation på Twitter *Politica*, 54(2), 129–147.

Johansen, N., Marjanovic, S. V., **Kjær, C. V.**, Baglini, R. B., & Adler-Nissen, R. (2022). Ridiculing the "tinfoil hats:" Citizen responses to COVID-19 misinformation in the Danish facemask debate on Twitter. *Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review*, 3(2).

Working papers

Kjær, C. V., Piqueras, M. & Johansen, N.*Did the bird need freeing? An explorative analysis of the content deleted by Twitter/X*

Kjær, C. V. & Pozsar, H. *Online Political Influence: The Role of Groups*

Kjær, C. V. *Online in-group dynamics over time. A story of crowding-out or pluralistic ignorance?*

Confrences & Workshop Presentations

Political Behavior Colloquium, *European University Institute* 2026
"Online Political Influence: The Role of Groups."

Political Behavior Workshop, *Aarhus University* 2026
"Online Political Influence: The Role of Groups."

APSA Annual Meeting, *Panel: "Social Media Engagement and Political Expression"* 2025
"Online Political Influence: The Role of Groups."

Media and Publics Conference, *Roskilde University* 2022
Did the bird need freeing?
An explorative analysis of the content deleted by Twitter/X.

Data Discussion Seminar, *Copenhagen Center for Social Data Science (SODAS)* 2022
Did the bird need freeing?
An explorative analysis of the content deleted by Twitter/X.

Awards & Grants

Early Stage Researcher Grant, *European University Institute* 2025–2026
Competitive internal grant for research expenses (€3,000).

Early Stage Researcher Grant, *European University Institute* 2024–2025
Competitive internal grant for research expenses (€4,100).

EUI US Exchange Programme (NYU), *European University Institute* 2025
Awarded competitive subsistence allowance (€4,000), [waived].

SPS Summer Academy Allowance, *European University Institute* 2021
Travel allowance (€400).

Teaching Experience

Political Persuasion in a Digital Reality, *University of Zurich (IPZ)* Fall 2026
Master's seminar: Adapted course on digital political persuasion for the IPZ curriculum.

Political Persuasion in a Digital Reality, *University of Lucerne* 2025–2026
Block seminar (BA/MSc): Original course on digital political persuasion;
supervision of seminar papers involving independent data collection and analysis.

Mentor, PhD Mentoring Program, *European University Institute* 2022–Present
Mentees: Nini Petriashvili, Nemanja Kidžin & Mathieu Dubied.

Tech Policy Course, *University of Copenhagen* 2021
Co-developed a course for professionals on governance of digitalization and technology.

Teaching Assistant, *University of Southern Denmark* 2016–2018
Political Theory and Introduction to Politics: Led weekly undergraduate seminars.

Certificate: Teaching and Learning in Higher Education, *European University Institute* 2025

Academic Service

Research Collaboration, *Global Deactivation Study* 2025–Present
Contributed to Danish data collection as part of a NYU-led international consortium

Review, Journal of Scandinavian Political Studies 2022

Skills

Methods: Online survey experiments; recruitment via social media advertising; agent-based modeling; social media data collection (API); large-scale text analysis; causal inference; qualitative content analysis.

Software: R (advanced), Stata, NVivo, LaTeX, Git/GitHub.

Languages: Danish (native), English (fluent), Swedish and Norwegian (working proficiency), Italian (A2-B1), German (A2-A1)